

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Zephaniah 1:1

The Lord gave this message: Zephaniah was a prophet, God's spokesman. • Hezekiah probably indicates the king of that name (see [2 Kgs 18:1-20:20](#)).

Zephaniah 1:1-2.3

Zephaniah's message from the Lord warns about worldwide judgment ([1:1-6](#)) and exhorts his readers to repent ([1:7-13](#)) before the devastation overtakes them ([1:14-18](#)) and to seek the Lord and live righteously and humbly before him in the hope that they may be spared his judgment ([2:1-3](#)).

Zephaniah 1:2-3

The list of the things that God will sweep away in his judgment is in reverse order to their creation ([Gen 1:20-26](#)): people and animals ... birds ... fish, because judgment is a reversal of creation.

Zephaniah 1:4

When Zephaniah made this prophecy, before Josiah's reforms in 622 BC, idolatrous priests rampantly promoted Baal worship and other forms of paganism ([2 Kgs 23:5](#)).

Zephaniah 1:4-6

Having pronounced judgment on the whole earth ([1:2-3](#)), Zephaniah now focuses attention on his own people, Judah and Jerusalem.

Zephaniah 1:5

Scripture denounced the practice of worshiping heavenly bodies such as the sun, moon, and stars (see [Deut 4:15-19](#); [2 Kgs 21:3](#); [23:12](#)). • Molech might refer to the Canaanite god Baal, the Ammonite god Milcom, or the pagan deity Molech.

Although the law explicitly prohibited Molech worship ([Lev 20:1-5](#)), it remained a constant temptation to Israel ([2 Kgs 16:3](#); [21:6](#)).

Zephaniah 1:7

has prepared his people for a great slaughter and has chosen their executioners: Foreigners will *slaughter* the wicked among the Lord's people.

Zephaniah 1:7-18

The entire passage must be seen as one vast event. Some aspects would be fulfilled at Jerusalem's fall in 586 BC; others would be repeated in various historical epochs (such as the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70) until the whole prophecy is fulfilled at the end of time when God acts fully and finally to judge the world and renew creation ([Rev 19:11-22:5](#)).

Zephaniah 1:8

The leaders and princes of Judah were the tribal chieftains of Israel ([Num 1:4](#)), court officials ([1 Chr 22:17](#)), district supervisors ([1 Kgs 20:14-15](#)), city officials ([Judg 8:6](#)), military leaders ([1 Kgs 2:5](#); [2 Kgs 1:9-14](#); [25:23](#), [26](#)), or even religious leaders ([Ezra 8:24](#)). Their influential role put them in a position of heightened responsibility before God (cp. [Isa 3:1](#)).

Zephaniah 1:9

those who participate in pagan worship ceremonies (literally *those who leap over the threshold*): The people of Judah perpetuated the pagan custom of leaping over the threshold of a temple to avoid contact with it, in deference to that pagan god (see [1 Sam 5:1-5](#)).

Zephaniah 1:10

The Fish Gate was in the northern section of Jerusalem ([Neh 12:39](#)).

Zephaniah 1:13

God would send an invading force to plunder Jerusalem. The destruction would come so quickly that those with ill-gotten gain would not survive to enjoy their wealth.

Zephaniah 1:14–18

The meaning of the day of the Lord broadens to include God's dealings with the whole earth.

Zephaniah 1:15

darkness and gloom: See also [Isa 13:9–10](#); [Joel 2:1–2](#); [Amos 5:18–20](#).

Zephaniah 1:17

grope around like the blind: An example of God's justice (see also [Rom 1:21–32](#)). Because God's people were blind ethically and spiritually (see [Exod 23:8](#); [Rom 2:19](#); [1 Jn 2:11](#)) and had sinned against the Lord and his commandments, they would incur the just penalties specified in God's covenant with them ([Deut 28:28–29](#)).

Zephaniah 2:1–3

In light of the horrifying spectacle he has described, Zephaniah calls on his nation to repent and humble themselves before God.

Zephaniah 2:2

Farmers threshed grain on windy hilltops. When they tossed the mixed grain and chaff in the air, the wind blew the chaff away while the heavier grain fell back to the ground. The opportunity to repent was a fleeting one.

Zephaniah 2:3

all who are humble: True humility involves submission to and dependence on God ([Pss 18:25–27](#); [119:142–144](#); [Prov 15:33](#); [18:12](#); [22:4](#)).

Zephaniah 2:4

King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon conquered the Philistine cities of Gaza and Ashkelon . . . Ashdod and Ekron. Gaza remained deserted, but the others recovered and continued into later times. Zephaniah does not mention Gath, the fifth major Philistine city (see [1 Sam 6:17](#)), which had either disappeared or become unimportant by Zephaniah's time.

Zephaniah 2:4–15

Zephaniah began his pronouncements with the Philistines, whose kingdom lay on Judah's west ([2:4–7](#)). He moved on to Moab and Ammon in the east ([2:8–11](#)), and finally singled out Cush (Ethiopia) to the south ([2:12](#)) and Assyria to the north ([2:13–15](#)).

Zephaniah 2:4–3:20

Zephaniah turns his attention to the judgment of the foreign nations ([2:4–15](#)) before returning to the judgment of Judah and Jerusalem ([3:1–8](#)). He then outlines God's plans for his purified and obedient people ([3:9–20](#)).

Zephaniah 2:5

Old Testament scholars believe the Philistines came from the island of Crete (cp. [Ezek 25:16](#)).

Zephaniah 2:6

pasture . . . shepherd camps and enclosures for sheep: The destruction of cities and their return to a natural state represents a severe form of punishment from God. See also [Isa 7:23–25](#); [13:19–21](#); [32:9–15](#); [Ezek 35:9](#).

Zephaniah 2:7

The Baal worshippers ([1:4](#)) and the Philistines would never be restored ([2:4–6](#); see also [Amos 1:8](#)). By contrast, God promised to return the remnant of his people to their land, care for them,

and restore them to prosperity ([Zeph 3:18–20](#); [Isa 11:11–16](#); [Jer 23:1–8](#); [Ezek 34:11–16, 20–31](#)).

Zephaniah 2:8

The Moabites and Ammonites were Israel's traditional foes. The Israelites fought with them frequently (see [2 Kgs 3:1–27](#); [2 Chr 20:1–30](#)), and they remained Israel's enemies to the end ([2 Kgs 25:25](#); [Jer 40:11–14](#)). • mocking . . . invading: The Israelites not only suffered repeated attacks by the Moabites and Ammonites (see [Amos 1:13](#)) but also endured their insults over their successes.

Zephaniah 2:9

The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah serves as an example of God's severe judgment of sin, both in the Old Testament ([Deut 29:23](#); [Isa 1:9](#); [Jer 23:14](#); [Amos 4:11](#)) and in the New Testament ([Luke 10:12](#); [Rom 9:29](#); [2 Pet 2:6](#)). • salt pits: A ruinous waste ([Deut 29:23](#); [Ps 107:34](#); [Jer 17:6](#)). Sowing the earth with salt was a mark of permanent judgment (see [Judg 9:45](#)) because it made the ground barren.

Zephaniah 2:11

nations . . . will worship the Lord: At the end of history, all people in all places will worship God alone ([3:9](#); [Ps 66:4](#); [Mic 4:1–2](#); [Zech 14:16](#)).

Zephaniah 2:12

Ethiopians: Hebrew *Cushites*. While the Hebrew term can refer to any nation or people along the southern edge of the known world of that time, here it refers specifically to the Ethiopian dynasty that ruled Egypt.

Zephaniah 2:13

Zephaniah turns from the south ([2:12](#)) to the north. Like Nahum before him, he announces the imminent demise of Assyria.

Zephaniah 2:14

To drive home his point about Nineveh's fate, Zephaniah invokes powerful imagery: Rubble would fill the doorways through which the wealthy and powerful of Nineveh had once walked. The eerie sounds of owls hooting in empty windows would punctuate the city's desolation.

Zephaniah 2:15

utter ruin: The doom was so certain and irreversible (see [Nah 1:14](#); [2:13](#); [3:19](#)) that Zephaniah saw no future for Assyria or its capital. So complete was Nineveh's devastation that the Greek historian Xenophon once passed by its ruins unaware that it was there. • laugh . . . shake a defiant fist: Those who suffered under Assyria's cruel empire would be glad seeing its demise.

Zephaniah 3:1

Polluted Jerusalem had wandered far from its call to be a holy city ([Isa 52:1](#)).

Zephaniah 3:1–8

Zephaniah pronounces a message of sorrow for Judah and Jerusalem and admonishes them to wait patiently for the results of God's righteous judgment.

Zephaniah 3:3–4

See also [Ezek 22:23–29](#).

Zephaniah 3:5

He does no wrong, unlike those mentioned in [3:3–4](#).

Zephaniah 3:7

get up early: Jerusalem's citizens couldn't wait to jump out of bed in the morning and do more evil deeds (cp. [Prov 1:16](#)). They had moved far from the ways of their ancestor Abraham, who arose early to obey God's command ([Gen 22:3](#)).

Zephaniah 3:8

be patient: See [Hab 2:3](#). • stand and accuse: The prophet portrays a courtroom scene where God rises first as witness (see also [Jer 29:23](#); [Mal 3:5](#)) on his own behalf, and then presides as judge (see also [Job 9:15](#); [Ps 50:6](#)) to deliver his righteous sentence. • The fire of my jealousy describes the Lord's righteous hatred of sin, as well as his concern for his holy name and for the welfare of his people (see [Isa 66:13–16](#)).

Zephaniah 3:9

God intends for the blessings promised to the faithful remnant of [3:9–13](#) to reach people from every nation of the world. Not just Israel, but all people would be transformed, call on the Lord (see [Isa 55:5](#)), and serve him (see [Isa 59:19–21](#); [Zech 14:16](#)). The spread of the Good News to all nations furthered the fulfillment of this vision ([Matt 28:19–20](#); [Rom 10:9–13](#)).

Zephaniah 3:9–13

The glorious future described in these verses provides further reason to wait patiently for the Lord ([3:8](#)). Like fellow prophets Isaiah, Nahum, and Habakkuk, Zephaniah uses judgment and hope as twin themes.

Zephaniah 3:9–20

God reveals his plans for a humble and purified remnant of his people ([3:9–13](#)) and encourages them to rejoice in the coming abundant blessings of their saving Lord ([3:14–20](#)).

Zephaniah 3:10

The rivers of Ethiopia are the distant headwaters of the Nile River. The ancient world considered the origin of the Nile a great mystery, so the expression speaks of the farthest reaches of the earth.

Zephaniah 3:12

Jesus the Messiah perfectly expresses the ethical qualities predicted for the godly remnant of Israel ([Isa 42:1–4](#); [53:3, 7–9](#); [Zech 9:9](#); see [Matt 11:28–30](#); [12:15–21](#); [Phil 2:1–8](#); [1 Pet 2:23](#)).

Zephaniah 3:14

Sing . . . shout aloud . . . ! Be glad and rejoice: The cumulative effect of these commands emphasizes that God's people will one day experience unsurpassed joy.

Zephaniah 3:15

The true King of Israel was always to be the Lord ([Num 23:21](#); [1 Sam 8:7](#); [Isa 44:6](#)). • will live among you: See also [Isa 54:4–8](#); [57:14–19](#); [62:10–12](#); [Ezek 48:35](#); [Joel 3:17, 21](#).

Zephaniah 3:17

a mighty savior: God was Israel's Divine Warrior and Redeemer (see [Ps 24:8–10](#); [Isa 42:13](#); [Hab 3:8–15](#)). One of God's titles is "the Mighty God" ([Isa 10:21](#)). This title also applies to the Messiah ([Isa 9:6](#)). • He will rejoice over you: Not only will Jerusalem and all Israel *rejoice* in God ([Zeph 3:14](#)) but God will also rejoice over them as a purified and faithful people (see [3:12–13](#)).

Zephaniah 3:18

I will gather you . . . disgraced no more: The Lord's assurance stands in stark contrast to the pronouncements at the beginning of the book, when God threatened to gather the nations to sweep the people of Judah from the face of the earth ([1:2–4](#)). Now he promises to gather up those who have been driven from Jerusalem and lead them safely home.

Zephaniah 3:18–20

The repeated use of I will in these verses underscores God's further assurances to his people.

Zephaniah 3:19

God will turn his people's former shame into glory and fame (see [Deut 26:19](#); [Isa 62:7](#); [Mic 4:6-8](#); cp. [1 Pet 5:4](#)).

Zephaniah 3:20

On that day: After a time of terrible wrath and judgment, the day of the Lord culminates in everlasting blessings for all who trust in him ([3:9, 12](#); see [Ps 2:12](#); [Isa 45:22](#); see also [Rev 19:11-22:5](#)). • I, the Lord, have spoken! Zephaniah's prophecy, entirely from God (see also [Zeph 1:1-3, 10; 2:9; 3:8](#)), is utterly trustworthy.